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The fourth floor of Razorpay's Bengaluru headquarters does not look like the office of one of India's largest fintech companies. Employees move briskly between meeting rooms, conversations spill into open workspaces, and the energy is unmistakably start-up—fast, informal, and quietly intense. Amid the bustle sits Harshil Mathur, dressed in a light brown blazer, relaxed and measured, belying the pace at which his company has grown.

Twelve years ago, that journey looked anything but certain. Fresh out of IIT Roorkee, Mathur and his friend Shashank Kumar started Razorpay in Jaipur before relocating to Bengaluru to be closer to the start-ups they believed others had overlooked.

Investors dismissed payments as a crowded market dominated by a few established players. Yet, the founders saw an opportunity—build for India's smallest start-ups and grow alongside them. That conviction has since transformed Razorpay from a payment gateway into one of India's largest fintech companies, processing over a billion transactions every quarter, handling annualised payments of more than \$180 billion and steadily inching towards a public listing.

In a conversation with *Business Today*, Mathur reflects on building through rejection, scaling with

customers, why value matters more than valuation, and what it takes to lead a company through constant reinvention. Edited excerpts:

Q: Looking back, what was the original thesis behind Razorpay, especially when investors believed the payments opportunity had already played out?

A: We started building in this space because we believed it was a problem worth solving. As we progressed, we realised we needed capital because payments is a business where you have to invest first and build over time. So, we started meeting investors, assuming they would understand what we were trying to build. Instead, we faced a lot of rejections. The common view was that payments was already a commoditised market with 20-30

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established players. Investors would ask us, “How are you going to create space for yourself?”

At the time, there were five or six dominant players. The top three alone controlled 85-90% of the market, so there was a perception that everything that could be built in payments had already been built. Our view was different. While there were many players, almost all of them were focused on large enterprises. In 2014, India's start-up ecosystem was just beginning to take off, and we felt nobody was building for very small start-ups. Everyone was solving for established businesses, but not for one- or two-person start-ups operating out of a room.

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